



HISTORY AS COMMERCE

Out of power for long and short of cash, the Bihar Congress's desperation has driven it to leasing out its headquarters

Photographs by RAJAN RAH

■ By Farzand Ahmed

For nearly a century, Sadaqat Ashram on the banks of river Ganga in Patna has been a witness to history. This was the place where Mahatma Gandhi, Dr Rajendra Prasad, J.B. Kripalani and Maulana Mazharul Haq stayed and guided the freedom struggle from; this is where India's first President Dr Prasad, after retirement from Rashtrapati Bhavan, spent his last days; this is the place where Jayaprakash Narayan strategised the Bihar Movement which changed the political contours of the country and gave the country its first non-Congress government in Delhi.

Spread over 20 acres, the ashram complex is split into two parts—one owned by the Bihar Pradesh Congress

Committee (BPCC) while the other is in the possession of the Bihar Vidyapeeth. But now a part of that glorious history is up for sale and realtors are queuing up to buy. "We have high regards for history but what do we do with the vacant land? We need funds to run the party. We have to save the property from encroachers also. So, if the land is commercially utilised and the money is kept in fixed deposit in bank, both purposes will be served," says BPCC chief Sadanand Singh.

Bihar Congress's desperation for cash is understandable. Ever since it gave way to the Mandal forces in the 1990 assembly elections, the party has been in a decline (it touched a low of

just nine seats in the 2005 assembly elections) and its membership has been drying up. Without requisite funds, BPCC is unable to even pay salaries to its 36 staffers at its headquarters. "Salaries and other establishment costs have become a burden," says BPCC spokesperson Prem Chand Mishra. "Carrying out mass campaigns to revive the party also requires funds," he adds.

Since the state unit gets a meagre Rs 2 lakh a month from the All India Congress Committee (AICC) and the Muzaffarpur District Congress Committee (DCC) contributes Rs 25,000, which amounts to nothing, Singh had to think about leasing this two-acre land, valued at Rs 50 crore, for 100 years.

Rs 50 cr is the value of the land that BPCC wants